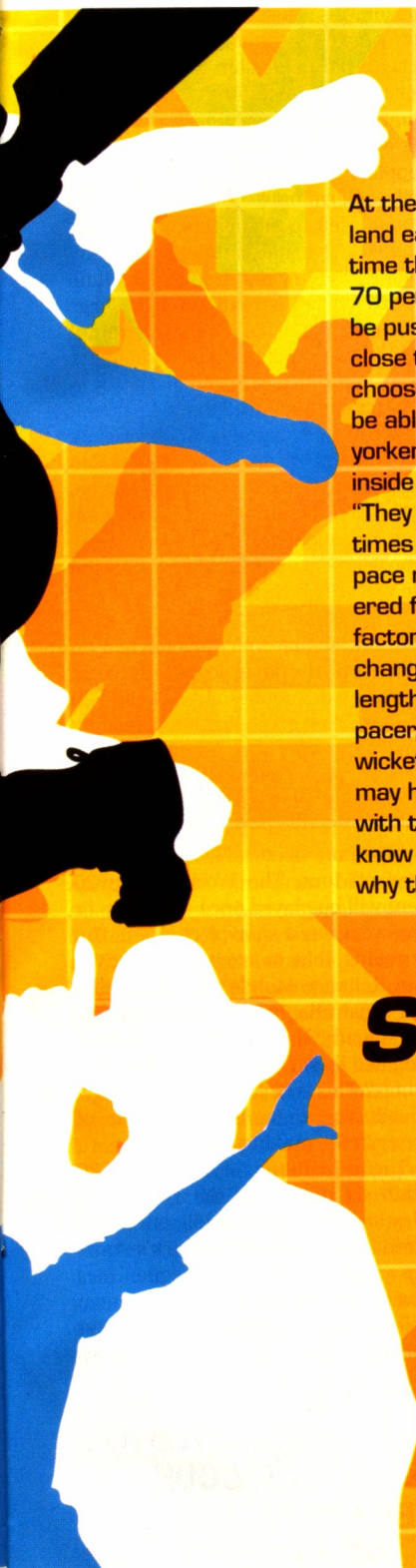




Bowling

At the moment the ability of bowlers to land each ball in their repertoire every time they try it varies between 40 and 70 per cent. In the future, bowlers will be pushing that degree of execution as close to 100 per cent. So, if they choose to bowl a yorker, they need to be able to finetune that to an offside yorker just inside the wide mark, to land inside the popping and return crease. "They must be able to hit that nine times out of 10," says Buchanan. The pace must be precise, it cannot be delivered from long run-ups due to the time factor, but it must have variety—swing, change of pace, yorkers, bouncers, length balls. The role of the medium pacer, who may be effective on slow wickets, will be put under scrutiny. He may have to develop a signal system with the wicketkeeper to allow both to know exactly where the ball is going and why the keeper is standing where he is.

Strategy

As the game is skewed towards the batsmen, bowlers, fielders and strategists—coaches, game analysts and captains—will divert their attention to reduce the number of boundary hits. This means precision in bowling, speed, anticipation and movement in fielding, and the increase in the concept of 'set plays' to have tactics set up before the game starts.

ings had shot through the roof, ESPNStar Sports had made a killing selling premium ad slots, India had stayed up well past midnight for a fortnight and all was bliss.

It is as if T20 was invented for us. India prefers its entertainment in glorious multicolour, with action, drama and music that lasts, oh, about three hours. At the Wanderers, the Indian victory provided the mandatory happy ending and even Shah Rukh Khan featured in the final scene.

The success of World T20, pertinently the Indian success in the event, has produced equal and opposite reactions. It has sent a shudder through the hearts of the purists and a gush of feeling through the marketing men whose sphere of influence is Indian cricket. Both sides shared the same thought, but from different points of view. They have seen the future of cricket and its name is Twenty20.

Twenty20 is cricket on speed. Not just speed the drug, but speed the force of nature. It is car-chase cricket, full-throttle, with no time or space for hesitation. It is also a familiar, beloved game played by millions in backyards with only one abiding rule: hit out or get out. Packaged with modern bells and whistles, crowds identify with it and respond to its clamour and vibrancy.

The seduction of the format is immediately apparent, and in India, the pressure to capitalise on it will be brought to bear on BCCI by its rich friends. This has happened before. Just after Kapil Dev's men won the 1983 World Cup, India was suddenly addicted to one-day cricket. The consequence was an overdose, dozens of unmemorable one-day events and, later, the entry of the illegal betting business that thrives to this day. India's ODI mania was channelled into an environment of utter excess by BCCI, in far less commercially saturated times than today, with far lower stakes.

So right now, as Indian consumers

**"I'D CERTAINLY LAY A
LARGE WAGER THAT
50-OVER CRICKET
WILL BE EXTINCT."**

◀ MIKE ATHERTON, FORMER PLAYER